Post Mortem Report: Apple “AirPower”

A cancelled, publicly announced product (2017–2019)

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Subject	Apple AirPower multi-device wireless charging mat
Outcome	Announced September 2017 - cancelled March 2019

1. Summary

“AirPower” was a wireless charging mat that Apple announced in September 2017 with the iPhone X. It was designed to charge an iPhone, an Apple Watch, and AirPods at the same time, wherever the user placed it on the surface, and Apple said it would arrive in 2018. Unfortunately, it never reached users.

In March 2019, Apple’s senior vice president of hardware engineering, Dan Riccio, confirmed the project was cancelled because it would not meet Apple’s standards, and apologized to customers who had been waiting. Several outlets described cancelling an already announced product as highly unusual for Apple.

2. Timeline

Date	Event
September 2017	AirPower is announced with the iPhone X and Apple Watch Series 3, with a vague “2018” availability and no price.
2018	The release gets pushed back repeatedly while Apple stays silent. Journalists report overheating and software problems.
September 2018	AirPower is absent from the next iPhone event, and most mentions disappear from Apple’s website. Reports describe 21 to 24 overlapping coils, interference, excess heat, and poor device communication.
March 2019	Apple releases new AirPods with a wireless charging case, but no AirPower mat to go with it.
March 29, 2019	Apple confirms the cancellation in a statement and apologizes to waiting customers.

3. What Went Wrong

Area	What happened	Project management failure
Technical	The design used 21 to 24 overlapping coils of different sizes so devices could sit anywhere. Interference and heat resulted from that decision.	A major risk was not fixed with a functioning prototype before the public announcement.
Software and firmware	Communication between the mat and the devices was unreliable, charge levels were inaccurate, and the custom controller chip had its own firmware problems.	Hardware and software problems compounded because integration testing came too late.
Requirements and trade-offs	Apple was unwilling to make the mat thicker or wider, or to give up the “place it anywhere” idea.	Non-negotiable requirements even if they meant project failure.
Planning and commitments	The product was announced well before it was ready, with only a vague 2018 date.	The schedule was promised before the product was determined possible.
Stakeholder communication	Apple was silent about the delay for a long time, and the wireless charging AirPods case was sold without the mat it was meant to pair with.	Customer expectations were not met.
Governance and decisions	Some engineers believed the design could never work heat management wise, yet the project continued for about a year and a half.	No one took those thoughts into account and still kept the project going until its demise.

4. Impact

- **Customers:** people who waited for the product and buyers of the AirPods wireless case, had to use alternative wireless chargers instead of the product promised from Apple.
- **Reputation:** rare public failure for Apple.
- **Cost:** Apple did not give a cost for the project, but the project took about a year and a half of public delay and an undisclosed amount of engineering effort without producing anything.

5. Lessons Learned

Communication

- Announce commitments only after the riskiest parts are proven possible. A public date turns an engineering problem into a reputation problem. If nothing was stated until the product was proven behind the scenes, they would not have needed to also fulfill customer expectations.
- Regular, status updates to customers and partners would have reduced the surprise of the cancellation. Although that would also be unusual for Apple.

Testing and validation

- Test feasibility early. A prototype with thermal and interference tests could have exposed the core problem before a public launch date.
- Hardware, firmware, and device software should be tested together as soon as possible.

Requirements and scope

- Rank requirements as must, should, and could, and agree on a fallback if things don’t workout. A mat that charges two to three devices in fixed positions could have been sold as a compromise between Apples vision and reality.

Closure

- Use clear cancellation criteria so a failing project is stopped sooner and at lower cost when milestones are not met.
- Close out openly after not meeting the promise. Apple’s statement was short and gave no cause, which left customers guessing with no real answer.

Sources

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